

Caretta caretta

Loggerhead turtle



Length 28–39 in
(70–100 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Aquatic

Status Vulnerable

Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide

Compared to most other marine turtles, the loggerhead has a large head and powerful jaws, capable of crushing crabs, lobsters, and other hard-bodied prey. In open water, it usually floats near the surface, but it stays near the bottom in estuaries and bays, surfacing only to breathe. Loggerheads breed only every 2 years—or sometimes longer—and lay up to 5 clutches of about 100 eggs.



Emys orbicularis

European pond turtle



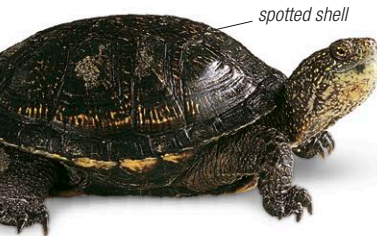
Length 6–8 in
(15–20 cm),
max 12 in (30 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Semiaquatic

Status Near threatened

Location N. Africa, Europe, W. Asia



This olive, brown, or black turtle is one of just 2 freshwater species that is native to Europe. Its carapace is smooth, and a hinge toward the front of the plastron allows it to be raised when the turtle withdraws its head, although adults cannot close the shell completely. These turtles spend much of their time basking on stones or logs, but they dive at the first sign of danger. They eat frogs, fishes, and other small animals, in water or on land.

Lepidochelys olivacea

Olive ridley turtle



Length 20–30 in
(50–75 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Aquatic

Status Vulnerable

Location Tropical parts of Atlantic, Indian, and Pacific oceans

The smallest sea turtle, the olive ridley turtle has an unmarked, dark or light olive carapace. An active forager, it takes crustaceans, fishes, and squid. It migrates in large numbers to its breeding grounds. Once, huge flotillas of turtles would arrive at sandy beaches to nest; human depredation has put an end to this spectacle.

Macrochelys temminckii

Alligator snapping turtle



Length 16–32 in
(40–80 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Aquatic

Status Vulnerable

Location S.E. USA

This formidable animal is the world's largest freshwater turtle, with a maximum weight reputed to be over 220 lb (100 kg). Like the matamoras (see opposite), it hunts mainly by sitting and waiting, but it is

Chrysemys picta

Painted turtle



Length 6–10 in
(15–25 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Aquatic

Status Least concern

Location North America

This freshwater turtle is one of the most widespread in North America, found in lakes, ponds, and slow-moving streams and rivers from the eastern seaboard to the far Midwest. There are 4 distinct subspecies; all have a flattened, smooth carapace, but some have red margins to their shells, a red stripe on the back, or yellow or red stripes on the neck. This turtle

Chelydra serpentina

Common snapping turtle



Length 10–18½ in
(25–47 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Aquatic

Status Least concern

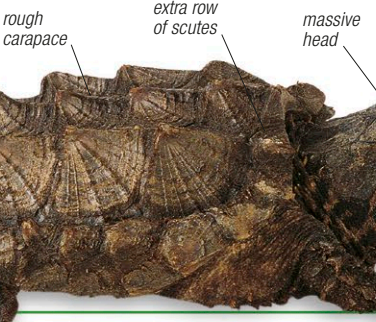
Location E. and C. North America, Central America, N.W. South America

This large, dark turtle is quick-tempered, biting ferociously when threatened. It has a massive head, a small plastron, and a rough carapace, sometimes covered with algae.

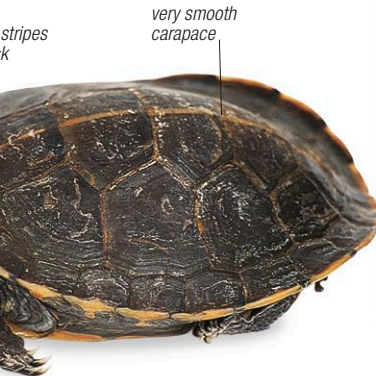


equipped with a lure that entices fishes toward its scissor-sharp jaws. At night, it is an active forager. Males spend their entire lives at the bottom of lakes or rivers, but the females leave the water in spring to lay clutches of 10–50 spherical eggs, buried in mud or sand.

ROUGH AND KEELED
The alligator snapping turtle has a rough shell, with 3 jagged keels, and an extra row of scutes on each side.



basks for long periods, especially in the morning, several individuals piling up on one another to bask on a favorite log. It is omnivorous and forages actively by day, sleeping on the lake bottom at night. Hunted by birds, fishes, and raccoons, it defends itself by hiding its head inside its shell, or by burying itself in mud. The painted turtle hibernates for variable lengths of time, depending on its location. Most females lay 2–20 eggs in 3 clutches, in chambers dug in sandy soil; not all lay eggs every season.



Inhabiting fresh and brackish water, preferably with plenty of plant life, it often lies buried in mud with only the eyes and nostrils exposed. It sits and waits for prey by day but at night is an active forager, lunging with its mouth open to engulf small mammals, birds, fishes, invertebrates, and plants. Mating may occur without preliminaries, but rituals in which the male and female face each other with necks extended have also been seen. Females lay one clutch of 20–30 eggs in a season, in a flask-shaped nest, often in a muskrat lodge; they can retain sperm from one breeding season to the next.



FISH LURE



During the day, this turtle lies with its jaws open and lures fishes by wiggling a small, pink, wormlike structure on the floor of its mouth. The hooked upper and lower beaks can deliver a powerful bite.

Clemmys guttata

Spotted turtle



Length 4–5 in
(10–12.5 cm)

Breeding Oviparous

Habit Semiaquatic

Status Endangered

Location S.E. Canada, E. USA

This small turtle has yellow spots on its black carapace, head, neck, and limbs. An omnivorous active forager, it is itself hunted by birds and small mammals. In summer, the semiaquatic spotted turtle estivates in the muddy beds of lakes and rivers or in muskrat burrows; it may hibernate in similar sites in winter.

